AUTHOR'S ACCEPTED MANUSCRIPT

Published in *European Journal of East Asian Studies* 25 (3): 325–351 (2026)
https://doi.org/10.1163/15700615-bja10009 | Please cite the published version.

Coordination Without Hegemony: RCEP and the Political Economy of Multipolar Regionalism in Asia

Dimos Chatzinikolaou[1,2*]

[1*]School of Business, University of Nicosia, Nicosia, Cyprus.
[2]Knowledge Management, Innovation, and Strategy Centre (KISC), University of Nicosia, Nicosia, Cyprus.

Corresponding author(s). E-mail(s): chatzinikolaou.d@unic.ac.cy;

Abstract

Multipolarity is usually treated as a shift in the distribution of capabilities, yet its practical consequence is institutional: who writes the rules, and with what domestic consent. This article asks how cooperation is organised when no power can impose order, taking the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP) as its case. An integrative review with theory-building purpose maps the Scopus literatures on multipolarity and the RCEP, synthesises a purposive pool of 36 studies, and anchors it against the treaty text and accounts of the negotiation. The synthesis supports reading the agreement as coordination without a hegemonic orchestrator: procedural leadership by the Association of Southeast Asian Nations steered the negotiation, while broad coverage with calibrated obligation preserves autonomy. Domestic authorisation is hypothesised, not shown, to be the binding constraint on deepening, with stated refutation conditions. The Multipolarity Governance Triangle organises these trade-offs as a heuristic and specifies indicators for testing it.

Keywords: Multipolarity, Mega-regionalism, RCEP, ASEAN, Polycentric governance, Multipolarity Governance Triangle

Author's accepted manuscript. This is the peer-reviewed and copy-edited version of the article, before typesetting by the publisher. Published as: Chatzinikolaou, Dimos. 2026. "Coordination without Hegemony: RCEP and the Political Economy of Multipolar Regionalism in Asia." *European Journal of East Asian Studies* 25 (3): 325–351. https://doi.org/10.1163/15700615-bja10009. © Dimos Chatzinikolaou, 2026. Published with license by Koninklijke Brill BV. Please cite the published version. ORCID: https://orcid.org/0000-0002-4138-8828. Online supplement: https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.21996163.

1 Introduction

Multipolarity has become a defining keyword of contemporary international debate, yet it remains analytically slippery: it is generally theorised as a distributional condition altering incentives for balancing and alliance formation (Mearsheimer 2001). Less often noticed is that polarity shifts also reconfigure the infrastructure through which cooperation is organised. Multipolarity is in that sense a governance problem, changing who can credibly supply collective goods, which institutions remain acceptable, and which rule-making arenas are feasible at all (Cox 1981; Keohane 1984).

That perspective matters because the present era presents a puzzle. A broad narrative of deglobalisation, weaponised interdependence and institutional fragmentation has gained ground (Farrell and Newman 2019). Yet the Indo-Pacific produced one of the most substantial mega-regional projects of the past three decades. Signed in 2020 by fifteen economies, the Regional Comprehensive Economic

Partnership (RCEP) overlaid the existing architecture of agreements between the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) and its partners with a single agreement spanning goods, services, investment, intellectual property and electronic commerce (Flach et al. 2021; Wardani et al. 2025). The timing is counterintuitive: if multipolarity is a story of division, why did so large a cooperative framework emerge precisely as rivalry between the United States and China sharpened (Bello 2023)?

The answer proposed here requires reframing the question. What is at issue is not whether multipolarity produces order or disorder in the abstract, but which kinds of order are available without a hegemon, and which institutional designs can hold heterogeneous members together. By coordination without hegemony this article means an arrangement in which no single member supplies the legitimating discourse, the enforcement capacity and the default rules together, so that authority over these functions is distributed rather than concentrated. Section 2.2 sets out the criteria by which it can be assessed. On the reviewed evidence, the RCEP meets it in respect of its members, though roughly a third of its text descends from the Comprehensive and Progressive Agreement for Trans-Pacific Partnership (CPTPP), whose provisions were largely negotiated as the Trans-Pacific Partnership (TPP) with the United States at the table, so the absence at issue is of an orchestrating hegemon, not of hegemonic legacy.

Mega-regionalism has been criticised as a source of regime complexity and fragmentation (Barbieri 2019), but under multipolarity it can equally be read as a practical response to coordination problems, and the RCEP exemplifies that logic: large in membership and economic weight, it is calibrated in what it requires, combining broad coverage with extensive exceptions and reliance on national implementation.

The article poses four questions. Why does contemporary multipolarity express itself through overlapping regional arrangements rather than universal institutions? Why did the RCEP materialise despite intensifying rivalry, and what does its deliberately incremental form reveal about cooperation under these conditions? And is domestic authorisation, meaning the process by which governments secure assent to external commitments, the binding constraint on deepening such cooperation, as this article hypothesises but does not claim to have demonstrated?

To address them, the article develops the Multipolarity Governance Triangle (MGT), which organises the trade-offs states confront among autonomy, connectivity and legitimacy. By legitimacy the article means only domestic authorisation, and Section 2.2 defines all three terms. The framework does not hold that these goals are jointly unattainable. It proposes that advancing one raises the costs of the others, and that those costs fall unevenly across members. Its status is that of a heuristic that generates propositions, not a formal model, and Section 5.3 specifies the indicators through which it could be operationalised and what would refute its central hypothesis.

The study is an integrative review with a theory-building purpose: it synthesises a purposive pool of studies from the Scopus literatures on multipolarity and the RCEP and anchors the synthesis against the negotiating record, the treaty text and accounts of ratification politics, so its findings concern how scholarship interprets the agreement (Section 3).

Two substantive claims follow, and a hypothesis. Contemporary multipolarity is usefully conceptualised as polycentric rule-making, in which multiple actors hold partial capacity to shape rules and cooperation proceeds through overlapping arrangements (Ostrom 1990). The RCEP institutionalises one mode of it, combining inclusive membership with broad coverage, calibrated obligation and built-in flexibility under ASEAN procedural leadership. The hypothesis is that how far that mode can deepen depends less on its economic case than on whether governments can secure domestic authorisation.

2 Background: Past, Present, and Emerging Futures of Multipolarity

2.1 Multipolarity as a Governance Condition, and at Which Level

Multipolarity is not a novelty, and the historical record is useful less as a blueprint than for isolating two problems any multipolar order must solve: making commitments credible when power is distributed, and sustaining assent when excluded actors or domestic coalitions do not benefit from the bargain (de Carvalho et al. 2011; Schroeder 1994). What distinguishes the present conjuncture, after a post-Cold War period widely read as a unipolar moment (Ikenberry 2011), is that deep economic interdependence coexists with strategic contestation. Technology and global value chains enabled industrialisation outside the traditional core (Baldwin 2016), while access to markets, finance and

standards became instruments of statecraft, so that trade institutions are arenas of competition as well as cooperation (Chatzinikolaou and Vlados 2024).

Because 'multipolarity' is used at several levels at once, this article fixes its referent. The claim advanced here is not that the international system as a whole is multipolar, a question this article does not settle, but the narrower claim that the regional rule-making environment in which the RCEP was negotiated exhibits plural authority: several parties held partial capacity to set or block rules, none could impose an outcome, and the United States, though not a party, shaped the available templates. Multipolarity in this article is therefore a property of a rule-making environment rather than of the distribution of global capabilities, and it enters the argument as a scope condition rather than as an independent variable whose variation is measured.

This article treats plural authority as polycentric: overlapping centres retain substantial autonomy, share rules-in-use, and coordinate through mutual adjustment rather than central direction (Ostrom 1990). The term specifies how distributed power is institutionalised; it is not a synonym for distributed power itself.

2.2 Defining the Three Dimensions, and the Vocabulary of Rule

The framework turns on three terms used loosely in this literature, each fixed here against the alternatives it might be confused with. *Autonomy* means retained capacity for national policy choice within an agreement: observable in reservations and exceptions, in the breadth of policy-space clauses, and in whether exceptions are self-judging or reviewable. It is narrower than sovereignty, which concerns formal authority rather than its exercise, and narrower than strategic independence, which concerns alignment in security affairs. *Connectivity* means the depth of cross-border economic integration that an arrangement supports: observable in trade costs, in utilisation of preferential rules, and in production-network participation. It is distinct from trade volume, which can rise without institutional support, and from interdependence, which describes exposure rather than institutional depth.

Legitimacy is used here in a deliberately restricted sense, that of domestic authorisation, meaning the processes through which a government secures and retains domestic assent to an international commitment. It says nothing about the normative justifiability of the agreement, and nothing about international legitimacy in the sense of recognition by other states. The studies reviewed in Section 4.2 suggest that the channels through which authorisation operates differ so sharply across members that the term must be indexed to a channel to do any work.

A parallel clarification is owed for the vocabulary of rule, since the article's title turns on it. *Hegemony* is used here in the demanding sense: a single actor supplies the legitimating discourse, the default rules and the enforcement capacity together. *Dominance* denotes the capacity to determine outcomes without necessarily supplying rules or justification; *hierarchy*, a settled and recognised ordering of authority; *market power*, the leverage conferred by size alone; *leadership*, the capacity to move others towards an outcome they can accept; *orchestration*, the shaping of process and sequence without commanding substance; and *institutional entrepreneurship*, the design of arrangements that make agreement possible. These are separable and can be assessed against evidence: who set the agenda, who blocked provisions, whose language appears in the final text, who can credibly threaten exit, and who bears the cost of non-agreement. Section 4 applies those the evidence reaches.

2.3 Regionalism, Regionalisation, and the Road to the RCEP

A distinction the literature sometimes blurs is basic to what follows. *Regionalisation* is the market-driven deepening of cross-border production and exchange; *regionalism* is the state-led construction of institutions over it, a distinction drawn in work predating the agreement and cited here as contextual evidence (Ravenhill 2010). East Asia experienced the first long before the second, so the RCEP did not create the integration it governs. It set rules around a regional economy that firms had already built, which is why its connectivity claims must be assessed against a counterfactual in which much of the observed integration would have occurred anyway.

Mega-regional agreements emerged partly from the limits of universal multilateralism, prompting warnings that overlapping rules would fragment the trading system (Bhagwati 2008). From a multipolarity perspective they are governance infrastructure: where no actor can supply a stable global rule-set, coalitions large enough to matter and small enough to negotiate can align standards selectively and provide a baseline for production networks without committing members to any single

power's rules (Velut et al. 2017). ASEAN's approach, combining inclusivity with incremental institutionalisation under the headings of open regionalism and centrality (Caballero-Anthony 2014), is best read as orchestration in the sense fixed above.

The RCEP's own formation bears this out. Two rival projects preceded it: China's proposal for an East Asian free trade area built on the ASEAN Plus Three grouping, and Japan's counter-proposal for a wider partnership including India, Australia and New Zealand. Neither sponsor could carry its own design, and in 2011 the two were merged under an ASEAN framework adopted at the Bali summit, with guiding principles agreed the following year and a declaration by sixteen leaders in November 2012. Negotiations opened in Brunei in May 2013, where ASEAN secured sole chairmanship against the partners' bid to co-chair, and ran to thirty-one rounds over some eight years. The American withdrawal from the TPP in 2017 lent urgency; India left as the text was concluded at Bangkok in November 2019; the remaining fifteen signed in November 2020 (Elms 2021; Fukunaga 2015; Iwasaki et al. 2025). The agreement was thus a compromise between competing designs rather than the project of any sponsor, which is the fact that most needs explaining.

The RCEP brings fifteen economies into one framework, the ten ASEAN members together with Australia, China, Japan, New Zealand and South Korea, overlaying existing ASEAN+1 agreements with a unified rule-set with common rules of origin (Flach et al. 2021).

2.4 From Policy Trilemmas to Multipolarity Governance

The trilemma vocabulary has a long lineage. Rodrik's (2011) formulation posits the joint impossibility of national sovereignty, hyperglobalisation and mass democracy, and comparable logic runs through the monetary and financial variants (Aizenman 2013; Schoenmaker 2011) and their macro-political extension (Stein 2016). Lewis (2024) generalises it to international relations. Vlados and Chatzinikolaou (2022) recast the trade-offs as a coordination problem under plural authority. Building on that move, this article develops the MGT, built on autonomy, connectivity and legitimacy, for settings where no hegemon underwrites the rule-set; Section 5.3 states what distinguishes it and what would show the distinction to be empty.

2.5 Research Gap and Contribution

Work on multipolarity, mega-regionalism and the Indo-Pacific remains segmented: multipolarity is discussed at the level of systemic rivalry, the RCEP as a trade-policy event, and the link between them, why particular institutional designs emerge under plural authority, is rarely drawn. This article addresses that gap by treating multipolarity as a governance condition of polycentric rule-making, using the RCEP as its case, and proposing a framework testable in domains where similar trade-offs arise, among them artificial intelligence, data sovereignty and the energy transition.

3 Methodology

3.1 Research Design and Type of Study

This article is an integrative review with a theory-building purpose, and its claims should be read accordingly. The evidence base is a body of scholarship, not the treaty record or the negotiating archive, and the primary findings reported in Section 4 are therefore findings about how that scholarship interprets the RCEP rather than direct measurements of how the institution behaves. Where the argument moves from the literature to the agreement itself, it does so through documentary anchors: the negotiating record, the treaty text and its schedules, and published accounts of member-state ratification politics. They establish plausibility and discipline the synthesis against the record; they are not tests, and statements about the RCEP as an institution are qualified to the evidence that supports them.

The design suits a question that spans fragmented literatures and requires conceptual generativity rather than exhaustive cataloguing (Snyder 2019; Whittemore and Knafl 2005). Three commitments follow from it. First, the analytical vocabulary of autonomy, connectivity and legitimacy is specified in advance, as a prior conceptual frame rather than an inductive result; Section 3.4 and Section 4.3 report what happens when the pool is coded without it. Second, screening applied a relevance rule fixed in advance; the purposive tier, drawn by dimension, is framework-informed by design. Third, all screening decisions, coding materials and robustness outputs are deposited in the online supplement (`10.5281/zenodo.21996163`), so that the selection can be audited rather than taken on trust.

3.2 Corpus Identification

Scopus is the primary bibliographic database, chosen for transparent and replicable retrieval, and the corpus was identified in two waves. The first, on 15 January 2025, ran a title, abstract and keyword query for multipolarity in the Social Sciences, all document types and languages, which returned 645 records, and a parallel query for 'RCEP' or 'Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership' from 2010 onward, which returned 506, or 253 after a subject filter the export does not record.

The second wave, executed on 26 July 2026, re-ran the same queries with the window extended and the subject filter documented explicitly. It returned 972 multipolarity records and 985 RCEP records, of which 869 remain after retaining Social Sciences; Economics, Econometrics and Finance; Business, Management and Accounting; Environmental Science; and Energy. The exact query strings, filter settings and export parameters are reproduced in the supplement.

The RCEP literature nearly doubled between the two retrievals, but the same query now also returns more records for past years, 143 for 2024 against 79 in the earlier export, because databases accrete retrospectively.

3.3 Screening and Selection

All 869 subject-filtered records were screened on title and abstract against a stated relevance rule, the screening executed by an artificial-intelligence (AI) model and spot-checked by the author, with borderline cases re-examined on the full record. A record was classified as *core* where its primary analytical object is the RCEP or the Asia-Pacific mega-regional architecture and its treatment concerns governance, political economy, institutional design, negotiation or membership politics, domestic politics, geoeconomic strategy, or regulatory and digital governance; as *contextual* where it engages the RCEP substantively but within a different primary question, or addresses the agreement through purely quantitative estimation with limited institutional interpretation; and as *excluded* where the RCEP is incidental, where the analysis is sectoral or technical without governance content, or where the record is not a scholarly contribution. Screening returned 229 core, 319 contextual and 321 excluded records. Each decision carries a one-line recorded reason, and the complete screening log is deposited in the supplement.

A body of 229 studies cannot be synthesised in depth within the compass of an article, so a second, explicitly purposive tier of 36 studies was drawn for close reading. The synthesis pool comprises the studies retained from the first wave, whatever their classification in the second, together with additions selected to ensure that each analytical dimension the review addresses is represented by work that treats it directly: the formation and negotiation of the agreement; the domestic politics of ratification and authorisation across contrasting political systems; regulatory and digital governance; power asymmetry and treaty design; legal architecture; hedging; and the contested question of ASEAN centrality, for which both supporting and sceptical positions were deliberately included. Each addition is recorded in the supplement with the dimension it covers and the reason for its selection. The remaining core studies are mapped descriptively by dimension, so that the pool's relation to the wider literature is visible.

A few works cited in this article lie outside this chain, because they predate the search terms, fall outside them, were not indexed, or fell at the subject filter; they serve as contextual evidence, never as pool members, and are named as such at the point of use and in the supplement.

This is a purposive rather than a probabilistic sample: a defensible basis for identifying recurring interpretations and building a framework from them, not for claiming that the distribution of views in the pool represents the field, which the descriptive map lets readers judge. Figure 1 summarises the full chain from retrieval to synthesis.

3.4 Analytical Procedure and Robustness Checks

The synthesis proceeded by close reading of each pooled study, recording its research question, its own analytical vocabulary, its principal explanatory factors and its specific claims about the RCEP, before any cross-study interpretation was attempted. Three checks were then run against the most serious threats to a design of this kind.

The first addresses circularity, and it is a supplementary robustness exercise rather than a validation. Because the three-part vocabulary was specified in advance, a synthesis organised around it risks recovering the categories it began with. Thirty-five of the thirty-six pooled studies were therefore re-coded under an open protocol that withheld the framework vocabulary entirely, and the results

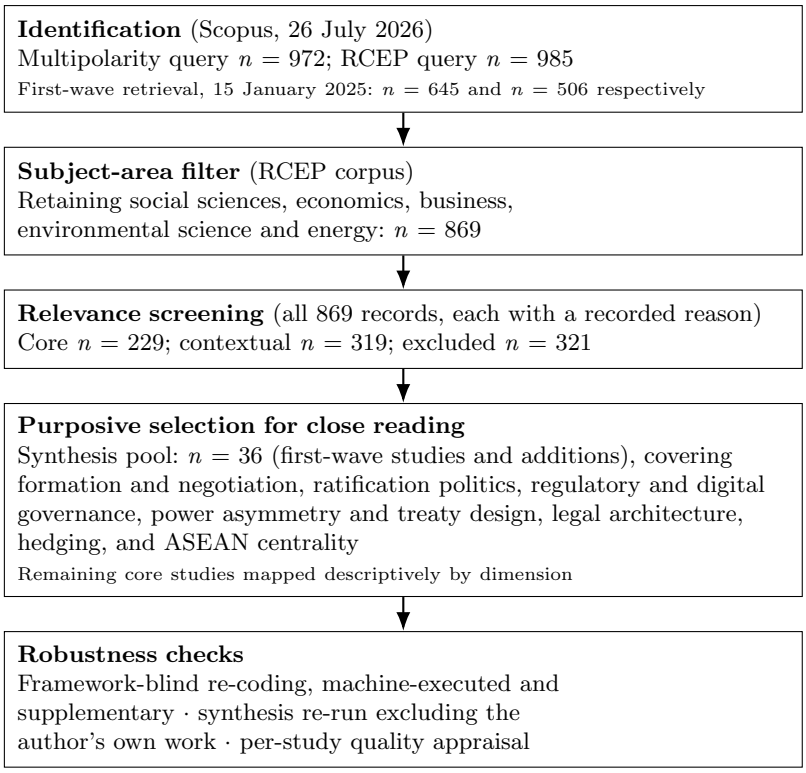


Fig. 1 Screening and selection flow, from database retrieval to the synthesis pool. Full logs are deposited in the online supplement.

were compared with the synthesis reported in Section 4; the thirty-sixth, a chapter of interviews with the negotiators, has no such pass, a gap recorded in the supplement. The blind passes were executed by large language models in eleven batches of one to nine texts, four of them grouped by theme, none given the framework vocabulary, the mechanism list or the earlier coding; the author specified the protocol and owns the comparison, and each pass was checked against its sources in a machine-assisted step that the author reviewed. All passes are deposited. What performed the check bears on what it establishes: such instruments were not shown the framework, which is the property the exercise needs, but they are not expert readers and supply no second expert judgement, and grouping by theme weakens the blindness of the passes concerned, so the result shows that the categories are recoverable from the texts, not that specialists would recover them. The blind coding also surfaced material the framework does not accommodate, reported in Section 4 rather than set aside.

The second addresses the influence of the author's own prior work, three items of which appear among the core records. The synthesis was re-run with the author's publications removed from the evidence base, and the effect on each mechanism was recorded. The mechanisms and their supporting readings survive the exclusion on the pooled studies alone, and the author's works are accordingly not counted as pool members. The author's earlier work is cited in Section 2 for its conceptual contribution only.

The third addresses evidential heterogeneity: each pooled study was appraised on method, geographical focus and evidentiary base, and works with direct evidence on a question anchor the corresponding synthesis while works that touch it peripherally corroborate. The appraisal table is deposited in the supplement.

3.5 Limitations

Four limitations qualify what follows. Multipolarity enters as a scope condition rather than as a measured variable, so the design cannot show that variation in polarity produces variation in institutional form; it observes one rule-making environment at one time. The review is Scopus-centred, largely English-language and subject-filtered, so policy reports, non-indexed regional journals and grey literature are under-represented; this matters most for the domestic politics of the smaller member states, where much relevant analysis is published outside indexed channels.

Coding was performed by the author, assisted by an AI model. The supplementary machine-executed re-coding, the recorded screening reasons and the deposited materials make the coding auditable but do not substitute for a second researcher, and because the blind passes were machine-executed, they do not supply an independent expert judgement. Finally, works available only in abstract form were subject to an obtain-or-exclude rule: full texts were sought for every pooled study, and any study that could not be obtained in full was removed from the synthesis pool and retained, where relevant, only as bibliographic context. The rule bound in two cases. A monograph and a book chapter identified as relevant could not be obtained in full text within the period of the study, and both were excluded from the pool accordingly, which therefore numbers thirty-six rather than thirty-eight; they are named with their reason for exclusion in the supplement. No claim in this article rests on either.

3.6 Use of Generative Artificial Intelligence

In preparing this manuscript the author used a generative artificial-intelligence assistant (Claude, developed by Anthropic) to support the drafting, condensation and linguistic refinement of the text, and to assist with the processing of the bibliographic corpus including the following tasks: the screening of records against the stated relevance rule, spot-checked by the author; the preparation of coding summaries from source texts; the checking of the blind passes against their sources; and the execution of the framework-blind re-coding described in Section 3.4, a supplementary robustness exercise whose provenance and limits are stated there and in the online supplement. The study's research design, the review protocol and screening criteria, the analysis, the development of the Multipolarity Governance Triangle framework, and all interpretations and conclusions are the author's own. The author reviewed, verified and edited all AI-assisted text, spot-checked the machine-assisted classifications, and takes full responsibility for the content of the article.

4 Findings

4.1 The Shape of the Literature

Publication in both literatures has accelerated, for reasons Section 3.2 shows, for the RCEP corpus, to be partly artefactual. What the corpora do show, and what bears on this article's premise, is that the two literatures are differently peopled. Nearly a third of the RCEP corpus carries a first-listed affiliation in China, which supplies under four per cent of the multipolarity corpus, where the United States, the Russian Federation and the United Kingdom together account for about 45 per cent. Venue overlap is correspondingly thin. That pattern is consistent with a separation of research communities, not only of subject matter, and it is the concrete form of the segmentation this article set out to address. The annual series, and breakdowns by country of affiliation and by venue, are in the online supplement.

Analytical attention within the screened literature is also uneven, in a way that matters for what follows: studies of the agreement's legal architecture and comparative design are numerous, while studies of the domestic politics through which members authorise it are few and cluster on a single case, India's withdrawal.

The imbalance may indicate that domestic authorisation matters less than legal design, or that it is harder to research, requiring language competence, country expertise and access to national debate, much of it published outside the indexed core. The review cannot adjudicate between these readings and the argument below does not depend on doing so; but any framework resting on domestic authorisation rests on the thinnest part of the available scholarship.

4.2 Five Mechanisms in the Literature

Close reading of the pooled studies yields five recurring mechanisms through which authors explain how the RCEP came about and what sustains it, each presented as a claim about the literature with its evidence and, where the literature divides, the terms of the division, the fifth being the article's own hypothesis. The mechanisms are analytical reconstructions that no author states in this form, and they describe how the agreement is understood, which is not the same as how it operates (Velut et al. 2017).

Mechanism 1 – Orchestration without rule-monopoly. The pooled studies converge on the observation that coordination among fifteen members proceeds through ASEAN procedural leadership rather

than through a single rule-supplier (Fukunaga 2015; Iwasaki et al. 2025; Pitakdumrongkit 2023). That leadership has observable content rather than merely honorific standing. ASEAN caucused internally before each negotiating round; every chapter was run by two co-leads, one from ASEAN and one from the partner countries; and ASEAN chaired the Trade Negotiating Committee, seven working groups and four sub-working groups (Elms 2021; Fukunaga 2015). Equally observable are its limits: ASEAN's proposals on open accession, treatment of the newer members, and economic and technical cooperation were largely adopted, while its proposal for periodic review was initially rejected (Fukunaga 2015).

On what that leadership amounts to, the literature divides, and the division is substantive rather than terminological. Fukunaga (2015) distinguishes ASEAN as 'the facilitator of process' from ASEAN as 'the driver of substance', arguing that the second does not follow from the first. Mueller (2019) reports it seen primarily as a clearing-house for Northeast Asian states whose own trilateral negotiations had stalled. Yoo and Wu (2022) go further, holding that centrality 'remains only a formality' while substance is supplied by external powers. Kim (2025) documents the structural version of the centrality claim, ASEAN being the only party linked to all others, while recording 'significant scepticism about ASEAN's actual influence' on the design itself.

One study allows this dispute to be assessed against the text rather than the process. Comparing the agreement's language against 111 prior treaties, Frank (2023) finds that roughly 31 per cent of the RCEP's text descends from the CPTPP, which the remaining parties concluded in 2018 after the United States withdrew from the TPP, whose text they largely retained, while Chinese and Indian treaty language is largely absent; even the investment chapter's apparently Australian provisions are themselves substantially CPTPP-derived. The finding tells against readings that treat the agreement as a vehicle of Chinese rule-writing, since little of the copied language is China's, though most of the text is new and its authorship untraced. It does not show that Chinese preferences were without effect: textual borrowing and political preference need not coincide, and a party can shape what is included, omitted or softened while drafting little of the text. But it also qualifies the absence of hegemony that this article's title asserts. No member state wrote the RCEP's rules alone; a substantial share came from language negotiated in the TPP with the United States at the table, transmitted through members that had taken part in that negotiation and carried its text into the CPTPP. What the case exhibits, then, is coordination without a hegemonic orchestrator rather than coordination insulated from hegemonic legacy, and Section 6 returns to the distinction.

The reading this synthesis supports is accordingly narrower than the one the literature sometimes asserts: procedural authority over the negotiation was genuinely ASEAN's, substantive authorship was partly inherited and otherwise not traceable to any single member, and no participant combined both.

Mechanism 2 – Broad coverage with calibrated obligation. The agreement is often described as thin and largely non-binding. On breadth the comparative evidence refutes it; on stringency it is partly right. On the Design of Trade Agreements (DESTA) depth index, which scores agreements additively across seven provision areas, the RCEP receives the maximum of seven, against two or three for the ASEAN+1 agreements it overlays (Kim 2025). It runs to some 510 pages across twenty chapters, with thirty-eight tariff schedules, a five-year review clause and a specified entry-into-force threshold (Elms 2021).

What is calibrated is the stringency of obligation, not the breadth of coverage, and the calibration is achieved through specific and identifiable devices. Dispute settlement under Chapter 19 excludes several chapters from its scope, including technical barriers, trade remedies, electronic commerce, competition and government procurement; there is no standing appellate body; and a complaining party ultimately determines for itself whether to suspend concessions, without the authorisation step the World Trade Organization (WTO) requires (Lando 2022). In the electronic-commerce chapter, apparently categorical obligations carry self-judging exceptions, discussed under Mechanism 4. Tariff liberalisation is shallower than the breadth suggests: its average tariff concession rate is 91 per cent, below the 93 to 94 per cent of the ASEAN–China, ASEAN–Japan and ASEAN–Korea agreements it overlays (Korwatanasakul 2026), with extended transitions for the least developed members.

The mechanism, stated precisely, is therefore this: the agreement achieves wide coverage by writing enforceable-looking commitments alongside the means of stepping outside them. Members accept a broad institutional perimeter because the perimeter binds loosely at the points where it would bind painfully. This is a more demanding claim than permissiveness, and a more falsifiable one: it predicts that where escape devices are absent, membership diversity should have prevented agreement, and that disputes should route to fora other than the RCEP's own. The agreement's incorporation of

existing WTO obligations makes that routing available (Lando 2022), but availability is a feature of the design rather than evidence of behaviour, and the prediction remains open until disputes actually arise.

It also carries a caution that the pooled studies support: permissive rules do not determine outcomes. Gains are mediated by position in regional production networks and by the governance capacity to use the agreement, so members realise very different outcomes from the same schedule (Li 2022), a pattern corroborated by sectoral evidence cited here as contextual (Tong et al. 2023).

Mechanism 3 – Participation as hedging. The pooled studies read membership as a way of keeping options open rather than as alignment: beyond tariff preferences, mega-regional agreements serve to structure supply chains and diversify dependence (Debroux 2020; Hung et al. 2019; Ji 2021). What hedging is for, and whose hedging is decisive, is disputed: second-tier states 'maneuvering between' the two powers (Hung et al. 2019); Japan's national role conception, which requires accommodation in several directions (Debroux 2020); South Korea's executive-led 'double hedging' with both powers in parallel (Choi 2018); and the agreement as the base of a polycentric order that China cannot carry alone (Kuznetsov 2018).

Two qualifications matter. Hedging is a property of state conduct, not of the agreement's design, so it explains participation rather than institutional form; and it is contingent on the rule-set remaining ambiguous enough to sustain several readings at once. Where economic security displaces commercial calculation as the governing frame, that ambiguity narrows, as contextual evidence from one sector suggests (Dzienis and McCaleb 2025).

Mechanism 4 – Digital and regulatory governance as the contested frontier. Data governance is where the calibration described under Mechanism 2 is most visible, and where the literature has grown fastest. The chapter contains genuine obligations. Parties may not require the use of local computing facilities as a condition of doing business, and cross-border transfer of information by electronic means is provided for. Yet each is paired with a public-policy exception whose necessity the invoking party determines for itself, unlike its counterparts in the CPTPP and the Digital Economy Partnership Agreement (DEPA) (Mishra and Palacio Valencia 2023; Zhai 2025). Special and differential treatment defers application for the least developed members for several years (Zhai 2025).

Whether this constitutes a distinctively Asian regulatory model or simply the lowest common denominator among very unevenly digitalised economies is contested. Mishra and Palacio Valencia (2023) treat it as a deliberate compromise permitting participation by states with incompatible domestic data regimes; Zhai (2025) reads the same provisions as an incremental path that developing countries might emulate; and Chen (2024) traces how one member's domestic regime has moved, showing that national rules can travel further than the treaty requires. The specialists also disagree on how demanding the personal-data provisions are; most pooled studies hold that the agreement resolves the tension between autonomy and connectivity in favour of national discretion.

Mechanism 5 – Domestic authorisation as a candidate binding constraint. The final mechanism is the article's most consequential claim and the one resting on the least evidence. It is therefore stated here as a hypothesis with a specified form, and probed rather than demonstrated.

The hypothesis is that the limit on how far the RCEP can be deepened is not economic but political: deepening proceeds only so far as member governments can secure domestic authorisation for it, and authorisation fails independently of whether the economic case is favourable. Two clarifications are needed before the evidence.

First, authorisation is not one thing. The pooled studies covering four members describe quite different routes by which domestic objections reach the authorising decision: in India, organised sectoral lobbies and electoral timing, with steel producers and dairy interests reaching the government through both industry associations and an affiliate of the governing party's parent movement, and withdrawal announced in November 2019 after adverse state election results (Dhar 2019; Singh and Singh 2020); in Indonesia, a contested process in which the executive managed business and civil-society objections discursively and parliament ratified only in August 2022, almost two years after signature (Karim and Putri 2023); in Thailand, where the only pooled study is a Bangkok survey, support for regional integration tracks individual awareness and exposure (Chancharoenchai and Saraithong 2022); and in South Korea, a trade-agreement strategy that the one pooled study, written before signature, describes as initiated top-down rather than by sectoral demand (Choi 2018). Any claim that legitimacy binds must therefore specify which channel binds where.

Second, the hypothesis needs a case in which authorisation failed while other conditions held. India's withdrawal is the obvious candidate and the weakest one, because it concerns entry rather

than deepening and because the economic case for Indian membership was itself contested. A better case exists within the agreement.

Investor–state dispute settlement was present in early drafts of the investment chapter, modelled on the ASEAN Comprehensive Investment Agreement, and was removed before signature. On the negotiators' own account, the removal was not driven by the distribution of power: no coalition of powerful states carried the provision. What moved was domestic politics in several members at once: an arbitration against Australia that made the mechanism politically salient, New Zealand's renunciation of the procedure in a parallel agreement, and above all a change of government in Malaysia, after which support was withdrawn shortly before the final round and other members followed (Lugg et al. 2024). The Indonesian side of the same episode is documented independently, with sovereignty and policy-space concerns recorded across several members (Wardani et al. 2025). One drafted provision fell while connectivity and procedural coordination continued undisturbed, and the question was deferred to a work programme requiring consensus (Lugg et al. 2024).

This is a plausibility probe, not a test. One episode cannot establish that authorisation binds generally, still less any particular functional form, and this one cannot separate authorisation from the consensus rule, from a region-wide backlash against investor–state arbitration or from the sovereignty concerns also recorded. It also has a bound: the provision was dropped before signature, so the episode belongs to formation rather than to post-ratification deepening. It is the stronger case, concerning a member that stayed and a provision already drafted, but it is about what could be agreed, not about what can later be added. What the episode shows is only that the hypothesis is not vacuous: on one documented occasion the outcome it predicts occurred, for reasons the episode cannot isolate. What would refute it is set out in Section 5.3, which separates authorisation failure from domestic opposition, and the first general review offers the natural setting in which to look.

4.3 What the Framework Does Not Capture

Because the three-part vocabulary was specified before the corpus was read, the synthesis above is vulnerable to recovering its own premises. The machine-executed re-coding described in Section 3.4 was run as a supplementary check on this risk, and its results cut both ways.

The reassuring result is that the phenomena the framework names were recovered without it. Passes run without the vocabulary identified ASEAN's procedural management of the negotiation, the graduated and exception-laden character of the commitments, the hedging conduct of individual members, and the domestic contestation surrounding ratification, which suggests that they are present in the literature rather than imposed upon it, though not that specialists reading without the framework would recover them.

The less comfortable result is that the blind coding surfaced a dominant theme that the framework does not accommodate, and several subordinate ones. The most pervasive organising idea across the pooled studies is not the management of trade-offs at all: it is great-power competition, with the agreement understood as a move within a sequence of moves. On this reading the RCEP is not primarily an equilibrium among autonomy, connectivity and legitimacy but a reactive institutional counter-move: China's proposal for an East Asian free trade area and Japan's competing proposal for a broader partnership merging under ASEAN auspices, then acquiring urgency from the American withdrawal from the TPP (Iwasaki et al. 2025; Ji 2021). Four further themes recur outside the framework: the contest over which party's rules become the template, where Frank (2023) shows inherited language prevailing textually, whatever the bargaining behind it; asymmetric dependence on a single large market, which several authors treat as the central fact about the region (Kuznetsov 2018; Yoo and Wu 2022); development gaps that determine whether members can use the agreement at all, on contextual evidence (Tong et al. 2023); and competition between models of economic order, in which the agreement figures as a state-centred alternative to a deregulatory template (Salamatov et al. 2022).

The framework can absorb some of this, since asymmetric dependence bears on autonomy and development gaps on connectivity, but only by retrospective accommodation, and the competitive dynamic itself would remain outside the account. The framework organises the conditions under which cooperation is sustained; the competitive dynamic explains why the attempt was made. Section 5 treats them as complementary, which is a choice about the division of explanatory labour, not a finding.

4.4 The RCEP and the Governance Triangle

Read through the framework, the synthesis of the pooled studies brings out a recurring pattern: the RCEP's design reflects persistent trade-offs among autonomy, connectivity and legitimacy that echo the policy-trilemma family discussed in Section 2.4. Figure 2 names those three dimensions. Members balance them without a hegemonic underwriter, and no single member can enforce uniform compliance across political systems this diverse.

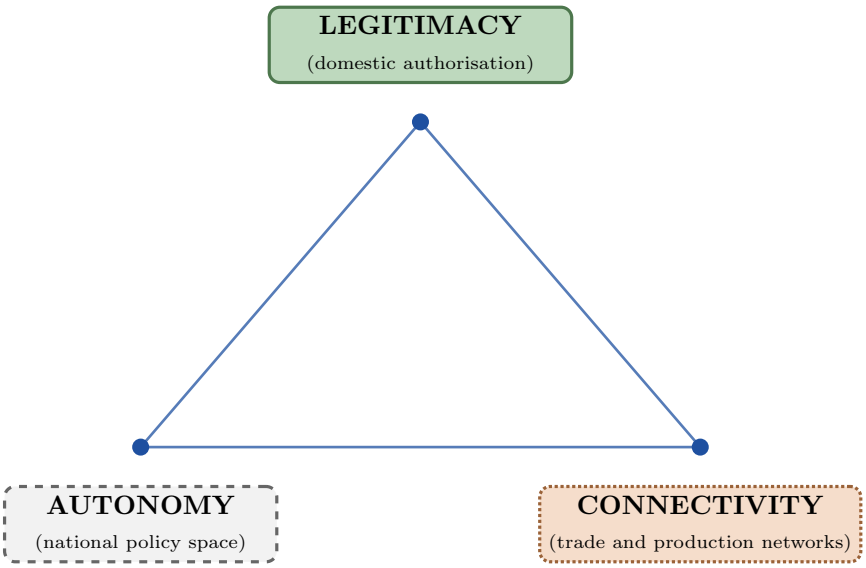


Fig. 2 The Multipolarity Governance Triangle. The figure is a conceptual schematic of the three dimensions and is not a measurement space; no position within it is claimed for the RCEP.

Taken together, the five mechanisms describe an arrangement designed to raise connectivity while remaining sovereignty-sensitive and dependent on domestic assent. The figure locates the agreement nowhere within the triangle, since that would imply measurement on scales not yet constructed; indicators for building them are specified in Section 5.3.

What can be said descriptively is narrower and rests on the evidence above. On connectivity, the agreement sets common rules across an already integrated regional economy, with gains mediated by sectoral and firm-level heterogeneity (Li 2022) and by governance capacity, on the contextual evidence noted above (Tong et al. 2023). On autonomy, its design preserves national policy choice through extensive reservations, calibrated schedules and self-judging exceptions (Lando 2022; Zhai 2025). On domestic authorisation, the record is uneven across members, and the investment chapter supplies one documented formation-stage episode in which authorisation, entangled with policy-space concerns, appears to have removed a drafted provision (Lugg et al. 2024). That unevenness, rather than any position in a diagram, is what the framework proposes.

5 Discussion

5.1 Why Coordination Took This Form

Theory suggests three reasons why multipolarity may favour overlapping regional arrangements over renewed universal multilateralism. Dispersed authority raises bargaining complexity, and clubs reduce the number of parties whose consent is needed (Keohane 1984). Openness, once underwritten by a dominant power, is now contested, and a reciprocal regional framework embeds it with redundancy against dependency and asymmetric vulnerability. And rule-making has become sectoral and modular, entangled with technology, standards and production networks, which suits agreements that combine tariff liberalisation with selected regulatory provisions short of full harmonisation. Multipolarity therefore need not mean fewer rules; it can mean more arenas, more overlap and more strategic navigation among them (Barbieri 2019).

The RCEP's feasibility follows from the same logic. Inclusivity lowered the costs of exclusion in a region whose production networks would have been damaged by fracture into rival blocs. Calibrated obligation lowered the costs of agreement: deep legalisation buys credibility at the price of sovereignty

and of authorisation costs that, on the hypothesis advanced here, the least willing members of so heterogeneous a membership were unlikely to bear, and a broad perimeter with usable exceptions was within reach. The corresponding risk is equally clear. Delegated implementation produces uneven compliance, and commitments that bind loosely invite informal influence by the members best placed to exercise it. The RCEP should be read not as a singular Asian response to great-power rivalry, but as one instance of a wider pattern in which states build layered regional infrastructure to mediate between global rules and local priorities.

5.2 Alternative Explanations

The reading advanced here competes with three others, and the case for it rests on what it explains that they do not, rather than on their being wrong.

The first holds that the RCEP reflects asymmetric dependence on China's market rather than distributed authority: the agreement codifies a regional order whose centre of gravity was already Chinese, and ASEAN's chairmanship is procedural cover. This account is strong on why members joined and harder to assess on what they signed. It predicts that the rules should register the preferences of the largest market, and the textual evidence can test only part of that prediction. Chinese treaty language is largely absent, and roughly a third of the text descends from the CPTPP, which China has not joined (Frank 2023); but provenance shows whose language was used, not whose preferences decided what was kept, omitted or softened. It tells against Chinese authorship of the rules, not against Chinese influence over their substance.

The second holds that ASEAN supplied procedural leadership without substantive authority, so that describing the outcome as coordination overstates ASEAN's role (Mueller 2019; Yoo and Wu 2022). This article accepts a considerable part of this. ASEAN chaired, caucused and sequenced, and its own substantive proposals were only partly adopted (Fukunaga 2015). The disagreement is narrower than it appears: what is at issue is whether procedural control over a negotiation among parties with divergent preferences is a governance function or merely an administrative one. The negotiating record suggests the former, since the agreement's shape was determined by what could be sequenced past objection rather than by what any party preferred (Iwasaki et al. 2025).

The third holds that the RCEP reflects institutional path dependence rather than innovation, a layer added to pre-existing ASEAN+1 agreements without replacing them, emerging when those agreements failed to adapt and under rivalry-driven diffusion among the larger partners (Korwatanasakul 2026). This is the most powerful of the three, though the inherited text comes partly from the CPTPP rather than the narrower ASEAN+1 agreements. But path dependence explains continuity better than choice: it attributes the agreement's flexibility to ASEAN's preference for incrementalism, which leaves open why that preference took the particular form of broad coverage with calibrated obligation rather than simply extending the existing agreements.

These accounts are not mutually exclusive: asymmetric dependence explains motive, path dependence explains material, and the governance account explains the form the result took. A fourth reading, set out in Section 4.3, has the strongest claim on the pooled studies: the agreement as a move between competing great-power projects, which supplies the impetus for which the other three supply the means, and which this framework is least equipped to extend. What the alternatives do not supply, and what the framework is for, is an account of the conditions under which such an arrangement can be deepened rather than merely maintained.

5.3 The Governance Triangle Beyond the RCEP

The MGT proposes that governance in a multipolar world is shaped by recurring trade-offs among autonomy, connectivity and legitimacy. It generates four propositions for future research. The first is that the more actors hold partial rule-making capacity in a domain, the more salient these trade-offs become, because no single actor can externalise their costs. The second is that institutions facing high membership heterogeneity will tend towards modularity and flexibility, because loosely binding commitments reduce sovereignty and authorisation costs. The third is that deepening will stall where domestic authorisation cannot be secured, however large the connectivity gains. The fourth is that leadership will be distributed across functions, with agenda-setting, process management, market provision and standard-setting performed by different actors.

As a heuristic rather than a formal model, the MGT claims only that the three dimensions are analytically separable, that advancing one has observable costs for the others, and that these costs are borne unevenly across members.

Making the framework usable requires indicators, and these can be specified even where they cannot yet be measured. Autonomy is observable in reservations and exceptions taken, in the scope of policy-space clauses, in whether exceptions are self-judging or reviewable, and in exposure to asymmetric dependence. Connectivity is observable in trade-cost reductions, in rules-of-origin utilisation rates, and in the depth of production-network integration. Authorisation is observable in ratification timing and margins and in coalition, ruling-party or executive reversals; stakeholder positions, public opinion and adjustment provision index opposition and its management. The RCEP's record on these indicators is uneven: its exceptions are extensive and several are self-judging, its coverage is broad, and its authorisation record varies sharply by member, as Section 4.2 sets out.

On the relationship to existing trilemmas, Rodrik's political trilemma does not presuppose a unipolar order (Rodrik 2011), and the distinction that survives is narrower. The trilemma literature, in Rodrik's formulation and its monetary and financial variants (Aizenman 2013), locates the trade-off within a single polity or mandate and resolves it by corner solution; the problem addressed here arises in a coalition without a guarantor and is managed rather than resolved. The framework earns its own name only if it explains something the trilemmas cannot, and the candidate is institutional layering: where the trilemmas predict a choice among objectives, the RCEP's members built an arrangement broad enough to postpone it. The full comparison is in Section S5.1 of the online supplement.

The domestic-authorisation hypothesis is falsifiable, and its terms are stated so that it can be refuted. It holds that authorisation is the binding constraint on deepening, and authorisation must be kept distinct from opposition. Opposition is objection by organised interests, parties or publics, and need not prevent authorisation. Authorisation fails only when a government cannot obtain the assent its own system requires: a legislative vote, the support of a coalition partner or ruling party, or, where the executive alone decides, a commitment that survives changes of government. Authorisation secured over sustained opposition therefore does not refute the hypothesis, which fails in two ways. It fails if substantive deepening, meaning a chapter brought under dispute settlement or a self-judging exception removed, stalls where every government could secure domestic assent, or if authorisation fails only where the economic case is unfavourable, since the binding constraint would then lie elsewhere. The first general review and the deferred work programme on investment dispute settlement are where both will become observable.

Policy conjectures that follow from the five mechanisms, and three trajectories consistent with the evidence, are set out in Section S5.2 of the online supplement as hypotheses for policy research rather than as advice.

6 Conclusion

This article has argued that multipolarity is better treated as a governance condition than as a polarity count: authority to make rules is dispersed, domestic assent is contested, and cooperation takes polycentric and overlapping institutional form. From that reframing it develops five mechanisms and the Multipolarity Governance Triangle, applied to the RCEP through an integrative review of the scholarship.

Two answers follow, and a hypothesis. On this reading, multipolarity favours mega-regionalism because universal bargaining becomes harder as preferences multiply, openness becomes contested once no power underwrites it, and rule-making has grown modular. The RCEP proved feasible by matching those incentives: inclusive membership lowered the costs of exclusion, and broad coverage with calibrated obligation lowered the costs of agreement for a membership whose least willing members, on the hypothesis, would not bear deep legalisation. The hypothesis is that domestic authorisation is the binding constraint on further deepening, since governments must secure assent through channels that differ sharply across the region's political systems. It rests on a single documented episode, which concerns what could be agreed rather than what can later be added, and it is bounded accordingly.

Three qualifications should travel with those answers. The first concerns the title. The evidence assembled here supports the claim that no member state combined procedural control with substantive authorship, which, since that authorship is traceable to no single member, meets the definition in Section 1; it does not support the stronger claim that the agreement was insulated from hegemonic legacy, since roughly a third of its text descends from the CPTPP, whose provisions were largely negotiated as the TPP with the United States at the table (Frank 2023). Nor does the faintness of China's textual footprint show that Chinese preferences left no mark on the substance. The absence at issue is of an orchestrating hegemon, not of hegemonic legacy. The second concerns the framework's

status: it is a heuristic rather than a model, and the indicators through which it could be measured are specified here rather than constructed. The third concerns the evidence base. This is a review, and its findings are in the first instance findings about a literature; the documentary anchors establish that the argument is consistent with the historical and legal record, not that it has been tested against it.

If the hypothesis holds, the most consequential question about arrangements of this kind is not whether they generate economic gains but whether governments can continue to obtain domestic permission to pursue them. The removal of investor–state dispute settlement from the investment chapter is consistent with that reading, within the bound stated above: on the negotiators' own account, a provision no powerful coalition would carry did not survive domestic politics in several members at once (Lugg et al. 2024). One episode does not make a pattern. Should the pattern be confirmed, the institutional sites of multipolar management would have shifted, and adjustment policy and domestic consent would matter to regional stability in the way alliance arithmetic once did.

Three lines of further work follow. The framework's propositions can be tested comparatively, against the CPTPP and other minilateral arrangements, by examining how specific provisions bear on the three dimensions. The micro-politics of authorisation deserves direct study, member by member, since this review found the relevant scholarship thin and concentrated on a single case. And the same trade-offs can be examined in domains where rule-making is still forming, including artificial intelligence, data sovereignty and the energy transition, where the costs of coordinating without a hegemon will be paid before the rules are settled.

References

Aizenman, Joshua. 2013. "The Impossible Trinity — from the Policy Trilemma to the Policy Quadrilemma." *Global Journal of Economics* 02 (01): 1350001. https://doi.org/10.1142/S2251361213500018.

Baldwin, Richard E. 2016. *The Great Convergence: Information Technology and the New Globalization*. Belknap Press. https://doi.org/10.2307/j.ctv24w655w.

Barbieri, Giovanni. 2019. "Regionalism, Globalism and Complexity: A Stimulus Towards Global IR?" *Third World Thematics: A TWQ Journal* 4 (6): 424–441. https://doi.org/10.1080/23802014.2019.1685406.

Bello, Walden. 2023. "From Partnership to Rivalry: China and the USA in the Early Twenty-First Century." *Journal of Contemporary Asia* 53 (5): 828–851. https://doi.org/10.1080/00472336.2023.2199760.

Bhagwati, Jagdish. 2008. *Termites in the Trading System*. Oxford University Press. https://doi.org/10.1093/acprof:oso/9780195331653.001.0001.

Caballero-Anthony, Mely. 2014. "Understanding ASEAN's Centrality: Bases and Prospects in an Evolving Regional Architecture." *The Pacific Review* 27 (4): 563–584. https://doi.org/10.1080/09512748.2014.924227.

Chancharoenchai, Kanokwan, and Wuthiya Saraithong. 2022. "Trade Policy Preferences: A Case of Thailand." *International Journal of Trade and Global Markets* 15 (1): 61–69. https://doi.org/10.1504/IJTGM.2022.120877.

Chatzinikolaou, Dimos, and Charis Michael Vlados. 2024. "New Globalization and Energy Transition: Insights from Recent Global Developments." *Societies* 14 (9): 166. https://doi.org/10.3390/soc14090166.

Chen, Meng. 2024. "Developing China's Approaches to Regulate Cross-border Data Transfer: Relaxation and Integration." *Computer Law and Security Review* 54: 105997. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.clsr.2024.105997.

Choi, Youngmi. 2018. "A Middle Power's Trade Policy Under U.S.–China FTA Competition: South Korea's Double Hedging FTA Diplomacy." *Contemporary Politics* 24 (2): 233–249. https://doi.org/10.1080/13569775.2017.1416735.

Cox, Robert W. 1981. "Social Forces, States and World Orders: Beyond International Relations Theory." *Millennium: Journal of International Studies* 10 (2): 126–155. https://doi.org/10.1177/03058298810100020501.

de Carvalho, Benjamin, Halvard Leira, and John M. Hobson. 2011. "The Big Bangs of IR: The Myths That Your Teachers Still Tell You about 1648 and 1919." *Millennium* 39 (3): 735–758. https://doi.org/10.1177/0305829811401459.

Debroux, T. 2020. "Japanese Multilateralism and the Balance of Power Policy in the Economic Field in Prime Minister Abe's Era." In *The Changing Global Environment in Asia and Human Resource Management Strategies*, edited by Bernadette Andreosso-O'Callaghan. Nova Science Publishers, Inc. https://www.scopus.com/inward/record.uri?eid=2-s2.0-85125410117&partnerID=40&md5=f8790e8f432e978a57cea4add856521a.

Dhar, Biswajit. 2019. "India's Withdrawal from the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership." *Economic and Political Weekly* 54 (45).

Dzienis, Anna Maria, and Agnieszka McCaleb. 2025. "Digital and Green Transitions and Automotive Industry Reconfiguration: Evidence from Japan and China." *Journal of Contemporary Asia* 55 (4): 618–644. https://doi.org/10.1080/00472336.2024.2384704.

Elms, Deborah K. 2021. "Getting RCEP Across the Line." *World Trade Review* 20 (3): 373–380. https://doi.org/10.1017/S1474745620000592.

Farrell, Henry, and Abraham L. Newman. 2019. "Weaponized Interdependence: How Global Economic Networks Shape State Coercion." *International Security* 44 (1): 42–79. https://doi.org/10.1162/isec_a_00351.

Flach, Lisandra, Hannah-Maria Hildenbrand, and Feodora Teti. 2021. "The Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement and Its Expected Effects on World Trade." *Intereconomics* 56 (2): 92–98. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10272-021-0960-2.

Frank, Nicholas. 2023. "Power by Proxy: Explaining Innovation and Imitation in the RCEP." *Global Governance* 29 (3): 322–345. https://doi.org/10.1163/19426720-02903003.

Fukunaga, Yoshifumi. 2015. "ASEAN's Leadership in the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership." *Asia and the Pacific Policy Studies* 2 (1): 103–115. https://doi.org/10.1002/app5.59.

Hung, M.-L., S. Yachin, and O. Granovskaya. 2019. "Between Integration and Confrontation: To the Prospects of a New Power Distribution in the Asia-Pacific Region." *Tamkang Journal of International Affairs* 23 (2): 1–30. https://doi.org/10.6185/TJIA.V.201910_23(2).0001.

Ikenberry, G. John. 2011. *Liberal Leviathan: The Origins, Crisis, and Transformation of the American World Order*. Princeton University Press. https://doi.org/10.2307/j.ctt7rjt2.

Iwasaki, Fusanori, Keita Oikawa, and Shujiro Urata. 2025. "The Road to the RCEP: Historical Background of Regional Economic Integration and the RCEP Negotiation Process." In *Political Economy of East Asian Economic Integration: The Process of the RCEP Negotiations and Beyond*, edited by Fusanori Iwasaki, Keita Oikawa, and Shujiro Urata. Routledge. https://doi.org/10.4324/9781032624044-2.

Ji, X. 2021. *Mega-regionalism and Great Power Geo-economic Competition*. Routledge. https://doi.org/10.4324/9781003177067.

Karim, Moch Faisal, and Sherina Putri. 2023. "Crafting Consensus: Indonesia's Discursive Strategies in Legitimising Free Trade Policy." *Contemporary Politics* 29 (5): 598–620. https://doi.org/10.1080/13569775.2023.2209395.

Keohane, Robert O. 1984. *After Hegemony: Cooperation and Discord in the World Political Economy*. Princeton University Press.

Kim, Soo Yeon. 2025. "Centrality and Community: ASEAN in the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership." In *Political Economy of East Asian Economic Integration: The Process of the RCEP Negotiations and Beyond*, edited by Fusanori Iwasaki, Keita Oikawa, and Shujiro Urata. Routledge. https://doi.org/10.4324/9781032624044-4.

Korwatanasakul, Upalat. 2026. "The Dynamics of Overlapping Agreements: Sequencing, Layering, and Feedback in East Asian Regionalism." *European Journal of East Asian Studies*, 1–29. https://doi.org/10.1163/15700615-tat00003.

Kuznetsov, A. V. 2018. "Integration Processes in the Asia-Pacific Region with the Participation of China and the Position of Russia." *Finance: Theory and Practice* 22 (6): 95–105. https://doi.org/10.26794/2587-5671-2018-22-6-95-105.

Lando, Massimo. 2022. "Enhancing Conflict Resolution 'ASEAN Way': The Dispute Settlement System of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership." *Journal of International Dispute Settlement* 13 (1): 98–120. https://doi.org/10.1093/jnlids/idac001.

Lewis, Olivier. 2024. "Trilemma Tradeoffs in International Relations: An Analytical Framework." *Global Studies Quarterly* 4 (1): ksae008. https://doi.org/10.1093/isagsq/ksae008.

Li, Xiaojun. 2022. "Who Benefits? Global Supply Chains and the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership." *Asian Review of Political Economy* 1: 6. https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s44216-022-00009-3.

Lugg, Andrew, Kirthana Ganeson, Manfred Elsig, Julien Chaisse, and Sufian Jusoh. 2024. "Why Is There No Investor-State Dispute Settlement in RCEP? Bargaining and Contestation in the Investment Regime." *Business and Politics* 26 (4): 449–476. https://doi.org/10.1017/bap.2024.8.

Mearsheimer, John J. 2001. *The Tragedy of Great Power Politics*. Norton Series in World Politics. Norton.

Mishra, Neha, and Ana Maria Palacio Valencia. 2023. "Digital Services and Digital Trade in the Asia Pacific: An Alternative Model for Digital Integration?" *Asia Pacific Law Review* 31 (2): 489–513. https://doi.org/10.1080/10192557.2023.2216058.

Mueller, Lukas Maximilian. 2019. "ASEAN Centrality Under Threat: The Cases of RCEP and Connectivity." *Journal of Contemporary East Asia Studies* 8 (2): 177–198. https://doi.org/10.1080/24761028.2019.1691703.

Ostrom, Elinor. 1990. *Governing the Commons: The Evolution of Institutions for Collective Action*. Cambridge University Press. https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511807763.

Pitakdumrongkit, K. 2023. "Managing Economic Statecraft via Multilateral Agreements: The Roles of ASEAN Member States in Shaping Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership." *Pacific Review* 36 (5): 1120–1147. https://doi.org/10.1080/09512748.2023.2200022.

Ravenhill, John. 2010. "The 'New East Asian Regionalism': A Political Domino Effect." *Review of International Political Economy* 17 (2): 178–208. https://doi.org/10.1080/09692290903070887.

Rodrik, Dani. 2011. *The Globalization Paradox: Democracy and the Future of the World Economy*. W. W. Norton & Company.

Salamatov, V. Yu., A. V. Tangaeva, and V. O. Kolomin. 2022. "RCEP in the System of Mega-Regional Trade Agreements." *World Economy and International Relations* 66 (2): 23–32. https://doi.org/10.20542/0131-2227-2022-66-2-23-32.

Schoenmaker, Dirk. 2011. "The Financial Trilemma." *Economics Letters* 111 (1): 57–59. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.econlet.2011.01.010.

Schroeder, Paul W. 1994. *The Transformation of European Politics 1763–1848*. Oxford University Press. https://doi.org/10.1093/oso/9780198221197.001.0001.

Singh, Surendar, and Ram Singh. 2020. "Domestic Sources of India's Trade Policy Preferences in RCEP Negotiations." *Journal of World Trade* 54 (4): 503–530. https://doi.org/10.54648/trad2020023.

Snyder, Hannah. 2019. "Literature Review as a Research Methodology: An Overview and Guidelines." *Journal of Business Research* 104 (November): 333–339. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusres.2019.07.039.

Stein, Arthur A. 2016. "The Great Trilemma: Are Globalization, Democracy, and Sovereignty Compatible?" *International Theory* 8 (2): 297–340. https://doi.org/10.1017/S1752971916000063.

Tong, G., R. Hong, and L. Shi. 2023. "The Growth Effect and Its Influencing Factors: Empirical Evidence Regarding China's Fruit and Vegetable Exports to RCEP Countries." *Agriculture* 13 (10): 1908. https://doi.org/10.3390/agriculture13101908.

Velut, J.-B., L. Dalingwater, V. Boullet, and V. Peyronel, eds. 2017. *Understanding Mega Free Trade Agreements: The Political and Economic Governance of New Cross-Regionalism*. Routledge. https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315200989.

Vlados, Charis Michael, and Dimos Chatzinikolaou. 2022. "Mutations of the Emerging New Globalization in the Post-COVID-19 Era: Beyond Rodrik's Trilemma." *Territory, Politics, Governance* 10 (6): 855–875. https://doi.org/10.1080/21622671.2021.1954081.

Wardani, Ranti Yulia, Nawalage S. Cooray, and Astri Hanna Waruwu. 2025. "The Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership as an Economic Architecture for the Asia-Pacific Amid Geopolitical Uncertainty." *European Journal of East Asian Studies* 24 (3): 376–401. https://doi.org/10.1163/15700615-02403002.

Whittemore, Robin, and Kathleen Knafl. 2005. "The Integrative Review: Updated Methodology." *Journal of Advanced Nursing* 52 (5): 546–553. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1365-2648.2005.03621.x.

Yoo, In Tae, and Charles Chong-Han Wu. 2022. "Way of Authoritarian Regional Hegemon? Formation of the RCEP from the Perspective of China." *Journal of Asian and African Studies* 57 (6): 1214–1228. https://doi.org/10.1177/00219096211049792.

Zhai, Dusheng. 2025. "RCEP Rules on Cross-Border Data Flows: Asian Characteristics and Implications for Developing Countries." *Asia Pacific Law Review* 33 (1): 24–45. https://doi.org/10.1080/10192557.2024.2417949.